
UX Research Analysis for Engoo's Material Selection

Introduction: The Design Context

In the digital language-learning space, platform design plays a crucial role in sustaining learner motivation and usability. Engoo, Japan's largest 1-on-1 online English education provider, delivers over 25,000 lessons daily to students around the world. As part of their expansive offering, Engoo provides internal "Materials" used during lessons, designed to suit the learner's level, language goals, and subscription tier.

This report investigates a key UX challenge within the Engoo platform: helping students choose the right learning material when booking a lesson. This task impacts how efficiently learners are matched with relevant resources and suitable tutors, and influences long-term student satisfaction and retention.

Through UX research, system mapping, and direct engagement with the Engoo platform, this report outlines the nature of the problem, explores its underlying causes, and proposes a brief to guide design improvements that align with both user needs and business constraints.



The UX Problem: Friction in Choosing Materials

The current process for selecting materials lacks clarity, contextual support, and efficient filtering. This results in students facing several pain points:

Cognitive Overload: Users are presented with a large catalogue of materials without adequate filtering or signposting. This contradicts **Hick's Law**, which shows that decision time increases with the number of choices.

Subscription Confusion: Students are shown materials that may not be available to them based on their subscription plan, creating frustration and dead ends.

Tutor-Material Mismatch: There is no clear way to find tutors who are aligned with specific materials or specialized in particular subject areas like "Business" or "Test Prep."

Lack of Upgrade Nudges: When a user encounters restricted materials, there is no elegant, persuasive prompt to upgrade their plan.

These issues compound to create a booking experience that is slower, more uncertain, and less empowering for learners especially beginners or non-native interface users.



An unintegrated and siloed experience

engoo

MATERIALS

Top

Daily News

LESSON MATERIALS

Engoo materials are free to use! Search by level or interest. [Learn more about levels.](#)

Level 1

Level 10

Beginner

Intermediate

Advanced

Proficient

Daily News

Our most popular material. New lessons added every day based on current events.

5

Intermediate

10

Proficient

Conversation

Improve your communication skills and have better conversations.

1

Beginner

7

Advanced

Business

Learn useful vocabulary and expressions for work.

6

Intermediate

8

Advanced

Travel & Culture

Learn useful phrases for traveling abroad.

5

Intermediate

8

Advanced

Describing Pictures

Increase your vocabulary and speaking skills by describing pictures.

4

Intermediate

8

Advanced

Grammar

Expand your knowledge of grammar and sentence structure.

2

Beginner

4

Advanced

Conversation Topics

Practice having conversations about various questions and topics.

4

Intermediate

7

Advanced

Vocabulary

Learn idioms, phrasal verbs, and other useful vocabulary.

7

Advanced

English for Young Learners

Learn the basics of the English language in a fun way.

1

Beginner

4

Intermediate

Pronunciation

Improve your pronunciation and sound like a native speaker.

4

Intermediate

Discussion

Read and discuss interesting stories and topics.

8

Intermediate

Health & Well-Being

Learn health-related vocabulary and expressions.

6

Intermediate

8

Advanced

World Literature

Read famous books, plays, and short stories in English.

9

Proficient

10

Proficient

Speaking Tests

Test your speaking skills and find your current English level.

2

Beginner

8

Advanced

IELTS Speaking Test Preparation

Prepare for the IELTS Speaking test.

4

Intermediate

8

Advanced

TOEIC® Speaking Actual Test

Familiarize yourself with the TOEIC Speaking test.

8

Intermediate

Decoding the TOEFL® iBT

Actual Test

TOEFL iBT® Speaking

Familiarize yourself with the TOEFL speaking test.

7

Advanced

READING ART Math PEOPLE

Elementary Reading Series

Improve your English while learning fun and interesting facts.

2

Beginner

4

Intermediate

Presented by

engoo

Engoo is a service that offers lessons for those learning English. Although the lesson materials can be used for self study, they are intended for use with a teacher. To book a lesson with one of our professional teachers, please visit Engoo. If you would like to use these materials for commercial purposes, please contact us here.

© 2020 - 2025 All rights reserved. All Rights Reserved.

engoo

Materials

Our Tutors

Blog

Plans & Prices

AI Roleplay

Contact us

FAQ

🔔

👤

Book a Lesson

Dashboard

My Page

Announcements

Favorite Tutors

Booked Lessons

Lesson History

Certificate

Test Call

Search for Available Tutors

Search for All Tutors

Study Language

English

Date and Time

07 08 09 10 11 12 13 14 17:30 23:30

Nationality

☒ Standard Tutors

☒ Native Tutors

☐ Other Premium Tutors

☐ Freelance

☐ Customize

Conditions

Age

Gender

Tags

Over 10 years teaching experience

Advanced

Beginner

Business

Kids

Speaking Test

Newest

Search

Free Word Search

Search

Clear

Showing 1 - 10 of 963

Native

Justin DP

4.99(1002)

South Africa

17:30

Reserved

18:00

Reserved

18:30

Reserved

19:00

Reserved

19:30

Reserved

20:00

Reserved

20:30

Book

21:00

Reserved

21:30

Reserved

22:00

Reserved

22:30

Reserved

23:00

Reserved

23:30

Reserved

Native

Colin

4.99(7483)

UK

17:30

Reserved

18:30

Book

19:00

Reserved

19:30

Reserved

20:00

Reserved

20:30

Book

21:00

Reserved

21:30

Book

22:00

Reserved

22:30

Reserved

23:00

Reserved

23:30

Reserved

Native

Delmarie

4.99(7071)

South Africa

17:30

Reserved

18:00

Reserved

18:30

Reserved

19:00

Reserved

19:30

Reserved

20:00

Reserved

20:30

Book

21:00

Reserved

21:30

Book

22:00

Reserved

22:30

Reserved

23:00

Reserved

23:30

Reserved

Native

Charles S

4.99(3871)

South Africa

17:30

Reserved

18:00

Reserved

18:30

Reserved

19:00

Reserved

19:30

Reserved

20:00

Reserved

20:30

Book

21:00

Reserved

21:30

Book

22:00

Reserved

22:30

Reserved

23:00

Reserved

23:30

Reserved

Native

Joe

4.99(7071)

UK

17:30

Reserved

18:00

Reserved

18:30

Reserved

19:00

Reserved

19:30

Reserved

20:00

Book

20:30

Reserved

21:00

Reserved

21:30

Book

22:00

Reserved

22:30

Reserved

23:00

Reserved

23:30

Reserved

Native

Steve

4.99(1270)

UK

17:30

Reserved

18:00

Reserved

18:30

Reserved

19:00

Book

19:30

Book

20:00

Book

20:30

Book

21:00

Reserved

21:30

Book

22:00

Reserved

22:30

Reserved

23:00

Book

23:30

Reserved

Native

Gary

4.99(2084)

UK

17:30

Reserved

18:00

Reserved

18:30

Reserved

19:00

Book

19:30

Book

20:00

Book

20:30

Book

21:00

Reserved

21:30

Book

22:00

Reserved

22:30

Reserved

23:00

Book

23:30

Reserved

Native

Bruce M

4.99(110)

Australia

17:30

Reserved

18:00

Reserved

18:30

Reserved

19:00

Reserved

19:30

Reserved

20:00

Reserved

20:30

Book

21:00

Reserved

21:30

Book

22:00

Reserved

22:30

Reserved

23:00

Book

23:30

Reserved

Native

Arthel

4.98(707)

Philippines

17:30

Book

18:00

Reserved

18:30

Reserved

19:00

Reserved

19:30

Reserved

20:00

Reserved

20:30

Book

21:00

Reserved

21:30

Book

22:00

Reserved

22:30

Reserved

23:00

Book

23:30

Reserved

Native

Thandi

4.98(15645)

South Africa

17:30

Book

18:00

Reserved

18:30

Reserved

19:00

Reserved

19:30

Reserved

20:00

Reserved

20:30

Book

21:00

Reserved

21:30

Book

22:00

Reserved

22:30

Reserved

23:00

Book

23:30

Reserved

1

2

3

4

5

...

97

About Us

Our Tutors

Materials

User Testimonials

Price Plans

Contact

FAQ

Contact Us

Engoo for Business

Apply to Teach

Terms and Conditions

Privacy Policy

Improve your English

Anytime, anywhere

engoo

f t i n o

© 2020 - 2025 All rights reserved. All Rights Reserved.

Bruno Hart IXXN 202 (300585980)

Who This Affects

This problem primarily impacts Engoo's **student users**, especially:

New students, who are unfamiliar with the platform and overwhelmed by choice.

Goal-oriented users (e.g. business professionals or test-takers) seeking tailored learning.

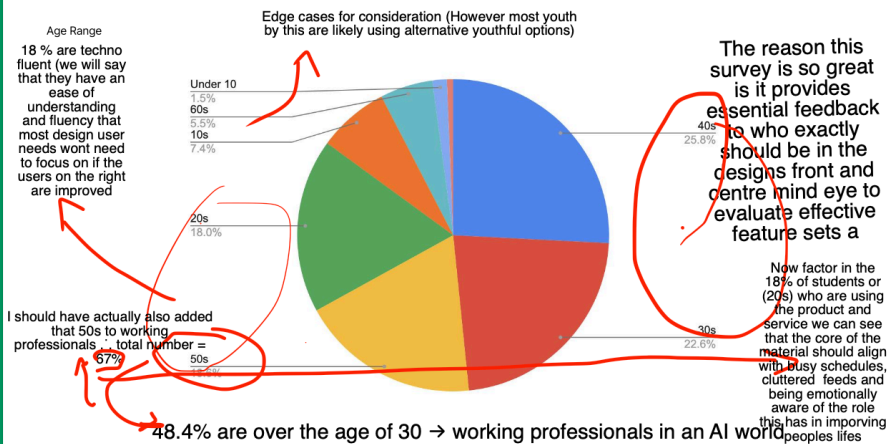
Users on free or basic plans, who need clearer distinctions between accessible and premium materials.

Non-English native users, who may struggle with UI comprehension when booking.

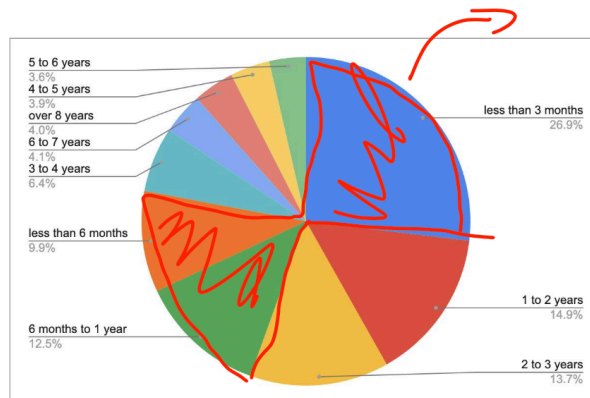
Secondary effects may also be felt by **Engoo tutors**, who may be paired with students using mismatched or misinterpreted materials impacting lesson fluidity and satisfaction on both ends. (See below for research insights into core demographic breakdown to inform design decisions)



Wow, this is such a rad research report. A+ for thoughtfulness, from me Mr Engoo Man



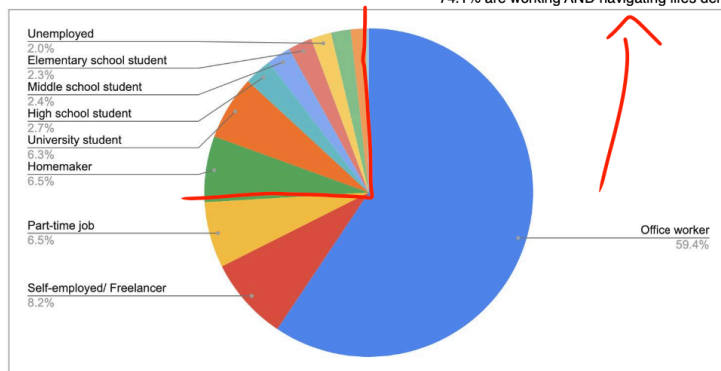
Time since sign up



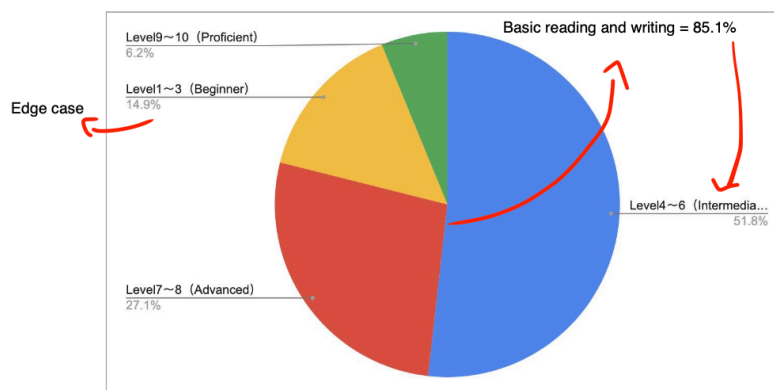
Total shaded pie = 48.3% with an extra 15% staying on for an extra year → suggests design of features should be impactful for accommodating a 1 year timeline → users should experience features that make sense for a 1 year maximum learning scale and so it is about making the material and tutor match as sticky, useful and joyful as possible so they get the most out of 1 year

Students Professions

74.1% are working AND navigating lifes demands



English Language Level



However the bulk are intermediate or advanced NOT fluent/ proficient ∴ there is a need for simple clear and effective directions that require less copy

Research Approach and Methods

Heuristic Evaluation: Conducted an expert review of the Engoo materials library and lesson booking flow, identifying usability issues including system feedback, visibility of system status, and flexibility of use.

Journey Mapping: Simulated a booking flow using a free account to capture a student's path from material discovery to tutor selection.

Competitor Analysis: Studied user flows from platforms like Cambly, Preply, and Duolingo English Test for material-tutor matching logic.

Secondary Research: Drew on UX literature including Nielsen Norman Group's article on "sludge" decision-making and Hick's Law applications.

Observations

- Navigation to the Materials Library is not intuitive from the homepage.
- Materials are organized by type, but not clearly labeled by access tier.
- There is no visual differentiation between content available to a user and content that is locked.
- There is no dynamic feedback or onboarding tool to guide users toward personalized or plan-appropriate materials.

Heuristic Analysis based on Personal Design philosophy (Respect to the Analog King Dieter Rams)

Nielsen's 10 Heuristics

Heuristic	Evaluation	Severity (1–5)
Visibility of system status	Lacks indicators showing if a material is available under current plan	4
Match between system and real world	Terminology and flow not intuitive to educational contexts	3
User control and freedom	Users can't preview or easily undo material selections	4
Consistency and standards	Mixed structure across materials and categories	3

Error prevention	System allows navigation to blocked content without forewarning	4
Recognition rather than recall	Materials require deep scanning to assess relevance	3
Flexibility and efficiency of use	No smart recommendations or shortcuts to recent content	3
Aesthetic and minimalist design	Content layout is dense with limited hierarchy	2
Help users recognize, diagnose, recover	No messaging or help links when user selects locked content	5
Help and documentation	No contextual tooltips or onboarding to support new users	4

Dieter Rams' 10 Principles

Principle	Evaluation	Score (1–5)
Innovative	Fairly conventional UI design, lacks innovation	3
Useful	Materials are useful but under-contextualized	4
Aesthetic	Functional but visually uninspired	3
Understandable	Structure isn't intuitive to most users	3
Unobtrusive	Does not distract, but also does not guide	3
Honest	Unclear material access boundaries may mislead users	4
Long-lasting	Structure will not age well without more flexibility	3
Thorough down to the last detail	Inconsistent hierarchy, labeling, and access pathways	4
Environmentally friendly	N/A (Digital)	-

As little design as possible	Adheres to minimalist principles but needs clearer visual cues	3
------------------------------	--	---

Competitor Comparison – Material Selection UX

Key Heuristic Violations in Engoo

- **Visibility of System Status:** No clear indicators of locked/unlocked status during material browsing.
- **Match Between System & Real World:** Students don't intuitively know which materials serve their goals.
- **Aesthetic and Minimalist Design:** The layout is text-heavy and lacks hierarchy.
- **User Control & Freedom:** No clear backtrack or preview options.
- **Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors:** No guidance if a user selects a material they can't use.

To refine Engoo's material selection UX, a heuristic competitor comparison was conducted against top platforms in the 1-to-1 and self-paced online English market: Cambly, Preply, italki, and Duolingo. The focus was placed on discoverability, user control, clarity of access, and integration between tutors and materials. This comparison leverages both Nielsen's Heuristics and Dieter Rams' design principles.

Platform	Material Discovery	Tutor Integration	Locked Content UX	Heuristic Insights
Cambly	Basic; buried in UI	Visible tutor specialties, weak linkage to materials	Abrupt blocks, no upgrade CTA	Fails "User control" and "Aesthetic integrity"
Preply	Material tagged by level and goal	Strong filter + tag system	Smooth nudging for subscription	Excels in "Match between system and real world"
italki	User-generated material, inconsistent	Tutor-driven experience	No clear material gating	Fails "Consistency and standards"

Duolingo	Highly gamified; level progression-based	No tutors (non-1-to-1)	Soft blocks with upgrade prompts	Strong “Feedback” and “Delight”
----------	--	------------------------	----------------------------------	---------------------------------

Findings & Opportunities for Engoo

- Cambly’s siloed approach makes it hard to use materials effectively.
- Preply excels in contextual linking between goals and tutor type.
- Duolingo’s onboarding and progression provide a model for soft gating and user engagement.

Engoo can differentiate by combining Preply’s structure, Duolingo’s engagement, and its own lesson material richness.

The biggest UX gap is Engoo’s fragmented experience materials should live alongside tutors and booking, not in a vacuum.



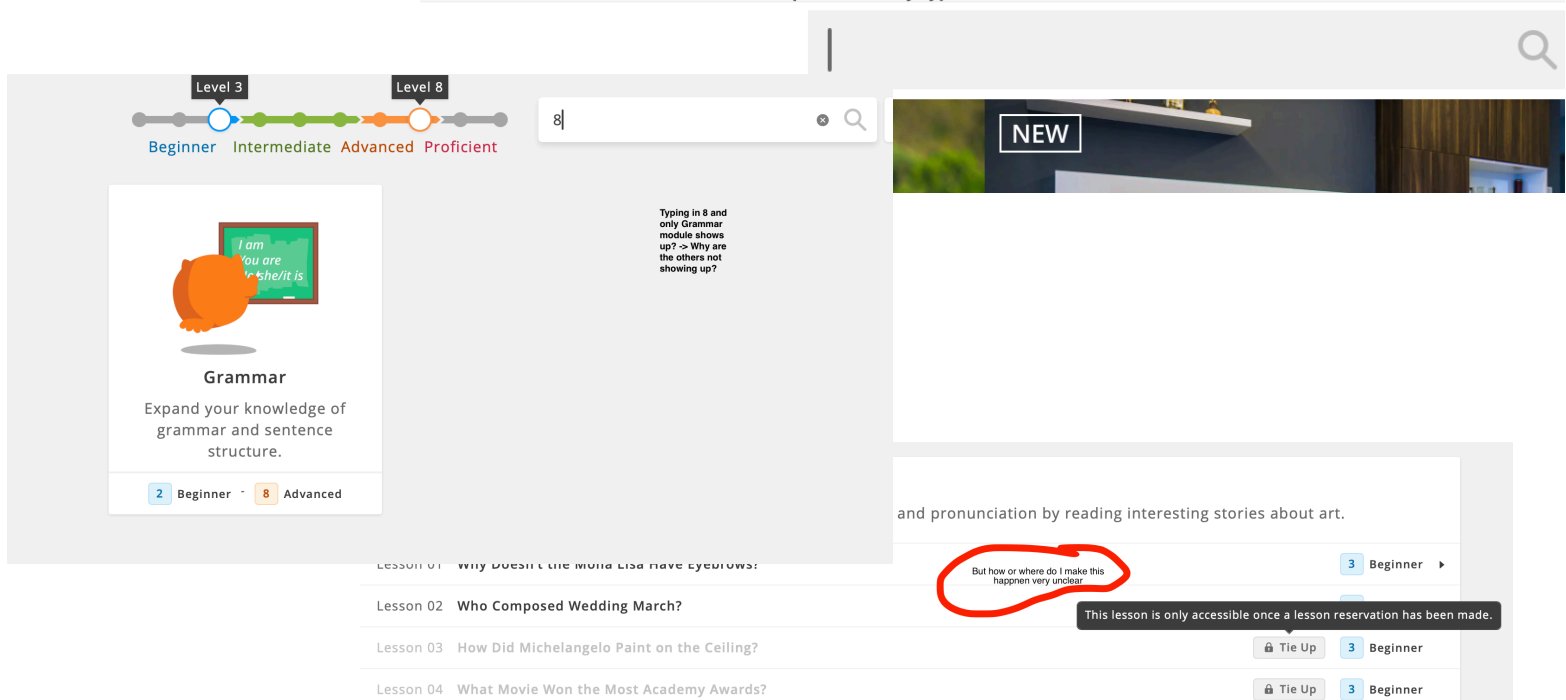
Quick Snapshots of investigation into small deliverables of UX language learning for Engoo



MATERIALS Top Daily News

There us no chnage in state between clicking on materials and top -> Why even make that clickable -> just remove Top -> its unnecessary and confusing

It's awesome that the search bar expands for my type



Engoo Material Selection – Student Journey Maps

Persona 1: Yuki – Business Professional

Age: 36 | Tokyo | Intermediate English Level | Engoo Plan: Business

Yuki is a full-time marketing manager using Engoo to improve her English for international client presentations. She needs fast access to relevant materials like Business English and wants tutors experienced in professional communication.

Step	Experience	Pain Points	Opportunities
Log In	Quick, seamless	No material suggestions	Show recommended business materials on dashboard
Browse Materials	Too many options	Cognitive overload, unclear what's available	Filter by plan & purpose; introduce preview mode
Select Tutor	Manual cross-check	No direct tutor-material match shown	Smart pair tutors to selected material
Book Lesson	Straightforward	No reinforcement of lesson goal	Confirm lesson intent in booking confirmation

Persona 2: Daisuke – University Student

Age: 21 | Kyoto | Beginner-Intermediate English | Engoo Plan: Standard

Daisuke is preparing for a semester abroad. He wants a simple, clear experience when choosing speaking and grammar practice materials.

Step	Experience	Pain Points	Opportunities
Sign Up	Mobile, easy	Too many options upfront	Intro tutorial or guided walkthrough of material types
Browse Materials	Finds conversation topic category	Can't tell which are free or locked	Add access badge: 'Included' or 'Premium Only'

Select Tutor	Likes video previews	Unsure who is best fit for material	Use compatibility badges like 'Great for grammar lessons'
Book Lesson	Confirms time	No confirmation of material focus	Reinforce selected topic in confirmation UI

Persona 3: Hana – Retired Learner

Age: 65 | Osaka | Intermediate English | Engoo Plan: Standard

Hana uses Engoo to stay mentally active and enjoys conversation with international tutors. She looks for daily news materials and pronunciation help.

Step	Experience	Pain Points	Opportunities
Log In	Simple	Struggles with English microcopy	Localised Japanese helper text for tooltips
Browse Materials	Enjoys browsing news	Doesn't know tutor requirements	Show tutor suggestions beside each material
Select Tutor	Filters by gender/nationality	No pronunciation-specific label	Tag tutors with specialisations
Book Lesson	Completes easily	Feels unsure post-booking	Add friendly reminder email of topic & tutor

Why This Problem Matters for the Engoo Business

Addressing this UX issue is essential to:

Improve conversion: Surfacing appropriate upsell opportunities (e.g. locked premium material with CTA to upgrade) could increase subscription revenue.

Enhance user trust: Transparent access signals and streamlined filtering improve cognitive clarity, reducing drop-off during booking.



Increase lesson success rates: When students are better matched with tutors and materials, outcomes improve and churn is reduced.

Align with real-world constraints: Rather than overhauling backend infrastructure, this challenge can be addressed through interface improvements that work within Engoo's current system logic.

Key UX Insights

Students experience decision fatigue. The cognitive burden this produces can be reduced through progressive disclosure and smart defaults.

There is low clarity around access to materials. This can be addressed by using design to differentiate locked vs. unlocked materials clearly

Tutor search is disconnected from material choice. As a result we could introduce dual filtering (material + tutor) or auto-recommend tutors post material selection

Upgrade pathways are invisible or jarring. It could be a possibility then to embed persuasive, subtle upgrade CTAs at key touchpoints

Key Constraints

Engoo operates on a high-volume model with over 6,000 tutors and thousands of lessons booked daily. Any proposed changes must:

- Avoid disrupting tutor availability logic or backend scheduling.
- Be localized for multiple regions and languages.
- Be scalable across subscription types and lesson categories.
- Require minimal retraining for tutors or student onboarding

Conclusion

Improving Engoo's material selection process is essential for reducing decision fatigue, boosting lesson success, and driving plan upgrades. This report identifies clarity, access, and tutor-matching gaps as key barriers, while recognising real-world constraints such as subscription rules, licensing, and system scalability. Edge cases like displaying inaccessible materials, handling expired plan content, and differentiating premium "tie-up" lessons inform a solution that balances transparency with motivation. By aligning interface clarity, contextual prompts, and adaptive filtering, the design can guide diverse learners effectively while respecting operational limits, ensuring Engoo delivers a smoother, more personalised experience that scales without compromising its global accessibility or business model.

